

WHEN THE TABLES TURN

Blue denotes power point slide

Brown denotes instructions to technician

TEXT: 2 Samuel 9:1-13 (NKJV) *“David said, “Is there still anyone who is left of the house of Saul, that I may show him kindness for Jonathan’s sake?”² And there was a servant of the house of Saul whose name was Ziba (Zee-baw). So when they had called him to David, the king said to him, “Are you Ziba (Zee-baw)?” He said, “At your service!”³ Then the king said, “Is there not still someone of the house of Saul, to whom I may show the kindness of God?” And Ziba (Zee-baw) said to the king, “There is still a son of Jonathan who is lame in his feet.”⁴ So the king said to him, “Where is he?” And Ziba (Zee-baw)*

said to the king, “Indeed he is in the house of Machir (May-kur) the son of Ammiel (Aim-ee-el), in Lo Debar (Low-dee-bar).”⁵ Then King David sent and brought him out of the house of Machir (May-kur) the son of Ammiel (Aim-ee-el), from Lo Debar (Low-dee-bar).⁶ Now when Mephibosheth the son of Jonathan, the son of Saul, had come to David, he fell on his face and prostrated himself. Then David said, “Mephibosheth?” And he answered, “Here is your servant!”⁷ So David said to him, “Do not fear, for I will surely show you kindness for Jonathan your father’s sake, and will restore to you all the land of Saul your grandfather; and you shall eat bread at my table continually.”⁸ Then he bowed himself, and said, “What is your servant, that you should look upon such a dead dog as I?”⁹ And the king called to Ziba (Zee-

baw), *Saul's servant, and said to him, "I have given to your master's son all that belonged to Saul and to all his house.* ¹⁰ *You therefore, and your sons and your servants, shall work the land for him, and you shall bring in the harvest, that your master's son may have food to eat. But Mephibosheth your master's son shall eat bread at my table always."* Now Ziba (Zee-baw) *had fifteen sons and twenty servants.* ¹¹ *Then Ziba (Zee-baw) said to the king, "According to all that my lord the king has commanded his servant, so will your servant do."* *"As for Mephibosheth," said the king, "he shall eat at my table like one of the king's sons."* ¹² *Mephibosheth had a young son whose name was Micha. And all who dwelt in the house of Ziba (Zee-baw) were servants of Mephibosheth.* ¹³ *So Mephibosheth dwelt in Jerusalem, for he*

ate continually at the king's table. And he was lame in both his feet."

INTRO: Examples of turning the tables would be:

- Football... (Reverse the field after each quarter)
- Basketball... (Reverse the court after each period)

(Story of Saul becoming King – Sinning against God – David being anointed King – Saul's jealousy – Friendship between Jonathan and David)

Through a violent battle with his archenemy, the Philistines, Saul was deposed as King and he and his sons, including Jonathan were killed in that very battle.

At this time, David began to rule over Judah and reigned for seven years and six months, at which time he began presiding over the entire nation and moved his governmental headquarters to Jerusalem. In the process of time David decided to find out whether there were any descendants of the house of Saul who remained. He discovered Jonathan's son, Mephibosheth was still alive but not quite well.

The story of the interaction between David and Mephibosheth teaches us the following lessons:

I. EVERYTHING IS NOT AS IT SEEMS...

David asked one of Saul's unemployed servants of the whereabouts of the descendants of Saul. Ziba revealed there

was one lone descendent of Saul, who happened to be the son of Jonathan but had been handicapped by a fall. Ziba revealed this descendant was living in the House of Machir in Lo Debar.

Mephibosheth, once a prince was now doing life as a pauper!

When Mephibosheth was five years old, his grandfather Saul and his father Jonathan were killed in a battle against the Philistines.

When the nanny who was caring for Mephibosheth heard of the tragic results of the battle she picked up five-year-old Mephibosheth, and made a run-for-it. In her haste to flee she dropped the child and he suffered a spinal injury. [In one tragic day](#), at

the age of five Mephibosheth: **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- Lost his mobility...
- Lost his position as a prince...
- Lost a very influential grandfather...
- Lost a father who no doubt adored him...
- Lost his ability to make a living because of his injury...
- Lost the security of being protected as a result of his family name...

Remember, everything is not as it seems!

Mephibosheth was living with Machir the son of Ammiel in Lo Debar. The name Ammiel comes from the Hebrew word “*ammiyel*,” meaning, “*People of God*.” The word Machir comes from the Hebrew word, “*makik*” (maw-kak) meaning “*To be*

brought low – decaying.” The place, Lo Debar was a pasture-less place in Palestine, probably desert and therefore more than likely it was a poverty stricken place.

Notice the sad trajectory of this once promising family with whom Mephibosheth was living: **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- At one time they were the people of God...
- They had been brought low...
- They were living in a poverty stricken place...

Remember, everything is not as it seems! God is able to turn the tables on the enemy!

This is where the story begins to turn! In this passage of scripture, Ziba is a type of

the Holy Spirit: **(PLACE ON THE
SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- David did not know if Saul had any surviving family members, but Ziba did...
- David did not know about Mephibosheth, but Ziba did...
- David did not know where to find Mephibosheth, but Ziba did...
- David did not know about the condition of Mephibosheth, but Ziba did...

Others may not know you are alive and in the condition you are in, but God the Holy Spirit does so you better get ready for your turnaround!

**II. MOST THINGS ARE BETTER
THAN THEY SEEM...**

ILLUSTRATION:

A young college student sent her parents the following letter:

Dear Mom & Dad,

I guess you have heard by now that my dorm burned to the ground. We were all in the basement smoking pot, and somehow we set the dormitory on fire. The good news is that no one was hurt; the bad news is that we lost all our possessions.

Before you get too upset about the smoking pot thing, I do not normally smoke pot but when I got drunk and totaled my car out at three in the morning I was depressed and was just trying to escape the pain of that unfortunate incident.

On another note I am getting married right away. This was not in my plans but I am pregnant and feel this will be the best course of action. My fiancé Bob does not have a job right now but he has a vintage Harley

and some of the most awesome tattoos you have ever seen. He has eighteen body piercings and some of the coolest jewelry I have ever seen for the piercings. I am so looking forward to introducing Bob to you guys as his parents were drug addicts and alcoholics and are in prison. He has never known what a real family is like. I think he is going to love our family.

Looking forward to seeing you soon

Your Loving Daughter

Betty Sue

P.S. Please see next page...

None of this is true but I did flunk chemistry and wanted to help you place this in perspective. Things could be worse!

Most things are better than they seem!

I am quite sure Mephibosheth was not an optimist. Listen to his words when he meets David for the first time. 2 Samuel 9:8 (NKJV) *“Then he bowed himself, and said, “What is your servant, that you should look upon such a dead dog as I?”*

The pattern for Mephibosheth seemed to be:
(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

- One failure after another...
- Frustrations that built one upon another...
- Dashed dreams that appeared to be forever gone...
- Disillusionments that appeared impossible to resolve...
- Disappointments that remained unsettled year after year...

Most things are better than they seem!

The life of Mephibosheth was about to become much better but until Ziba knocked on the door and David revealed his intentions, Mephibosheth assumed his life would be permanently pitiful.

Most things are better than they seem!

David didn't owe Mephibosheth anything neither did God owe us anything. 2 Samuel 9:1 (NKJV) ***“David said, “Is there still anyone who is left of the house of Saul, that I may show him kindness for Jonathan’s sake?”***

Every act of kindness and generosity from David to Mephibosheth was for Jonathan's sake! David searched Mephibosheth out

with intentions of blessing, because of his relationship with Jonathan.

Feelings of unworthiness and pessimism are a result of our assessment of what we deserve based on all the mistakes we have made along the way. Most things are better than they seem!

If we feel undeserving of being loved by a Holy God who cannot lie or make a mistake, we have rightly assessed the situation. None of us deserve to be loved or blessed by God! God has decided to love us and show us His kindness for Jesus' sake! Most things are better than they seem!

III. PAST AND PRESENT CIRCUMSTANCES SHOULD NOT BE

ALLOWED TO DETERMINE FUTURE SUCCESS...

It never occurred to Mephibosheth that the King might have summoned him for the purpose of doing him good rather than evil.

Because of years of living in hopelessness Mephibosheth assumed nothing good could befall him. Once hope is lost, self-destructive behavior sets in. **When one begins to participate in self-destructive behavior: (PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- Blessings are turned to rubbish through negligence... (One may not have the best car in the neighborhood but it should at least be kept clean)
- Opportunities are obscured by pessimistic behavior... (When personal expectations are that nothing good is

going to happen, one tends to miss any opportunity for success)

- The prospect of improved conditions becomes clouded by skepticism...

(When one allows his/her behavior to be clouded with sarcasm, the chances of the circumstances improving by any measureable increment is slim to none)

Thomas Jefferson said, *“I like the dreams of the future better than the history of the past.”* Will we allow our past and present circumstances to determine our future success?

Take a look at the Bible characters that allowed their promising lives to be downgraded to a lack luster existence:

- Samson... (The amazing Nazarite became a spectacle of insidious insults)

- David... (From giant killer to a passive, adulterous King who sat idly by as his own son attempted to usurp his throne)
- Judas... (From confidant of God's Son to a demon possessed suicidal maniac)
- Demas... (From disciple of the Lord Jesus Christ to a pleasure loving has been)

King David revealed his intentions to Mephibosheth! David was intent on placing Mephibosheth in a position of being blessed by the King and the Kingdom!

Father God has sent the High Sheriff of Heaven (The Holy Spirit) to CT Church to arrest (Convict) you today, not to bring you to justice but to reposition you for blessing! Will you allow past and present circumstances to dictate future success?

What is your response? You can keep living in a poverty-stricken, self-destructive, downward spiraling, and hopelessly depressing position if you so choose. But you don't have to! God is here to turn the tables!

IV. THOUGH DELIBERATE, THE PLAN OF GOD IS BRILLIANT...

God did not come up with a plan for Mephibosheth on the day David summoned him to the palace. The plan of God was at work in the life of Mephibosheth:

- Before he was born into the family line of Saul...
- Before his father and David became best friends...
- Before his father and grandfather were killed...

- Before he was orphaned and placed in the house of Machir...
- Before his fortunes turned from promising to pathetic...
- Before he knew who Ziba, the servant of David was...
- Before he was summoned to the palace...
- Before he met the King...
- Before his fortunes were restored...
- Before he was invited to eat at the Kings table...

The story of Mephibosheth reiterates to us the following principles: **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- God is never without a plan for us...
- God does not rush to reveal His plan to us...
- God is capable of working His plan despite our present circumstances...

Think of this:

- God made Abraham the father to nations even though he was an impatient liar...
- God called Moses to be a deliverer even though he was a murderer...
- God anointed David to be King of Israel even though his resume' was a bit thin...
- God called Paul to be an Apostle even though his past actions had proven him to be an angry, self-absorbed, murdering maniac...

God has a brilliant, SLOW DEVELOPING plan for each of us despite the baggage of the past. **(LEAVE ON THE SCREEN UNTIL NEXT SLIDE)**

The reason the plan of God is so slow to develop is:

- God is helping us unpack our past baggage so we do not use it to mess up His brilliant plan for our future...
- God is behind the scenes arranging hundreds of details so that they will all converge in the right place, at exactly the right time, for the right purpose...
- God is determined to not allow His plan to come to pass prematurely in order to keep us from messing up a set up...

While Mephibosheth was languishing in the house of Machir in Lo Debar:

- God was placing sticky notes in the mind of David concerning his relationship with Jonathan...
- God was texting Ziba thoughts of the plight of the lame son of Jonathan...
- God was e-mailing Ziba the google earth position of the only known survivor of the house of Jonathan...

- God was positioning Ziba to be the trusted servant of David...
- God was influencing the heart of Machir to be willing to share his resources with Mephibosheth until God was ready to relocate him to the palace...

Though deliberate, the plan of God was brilliant in the life of Mephibosheth! This plan included: **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- Rescue from living in a poverty stricken desert place...
- Being brought into the presence of the King of the land...
- The kindness of the King and Kingdom being demonstrated in his life...
- Restoration of all the wealth of his father and grandfather... 2 Samuel 9:7
(NKJV) *David said to him, "I will restore to you all the land of Saul your grandfather."* Vs. 9 *"The king called to*

*Ziba, Saul's servant, and said to him,
“I have given to your master's son all
that belonged to Saul and to all his
house.”*

- Assigning Ziba, his 15 sons and twenty servants to become custodians of all the property that had been returned to Mephibosheth...
- Eating every meal at the Kings table...
- Living in the palace, never to return to the house of Machir in Lo Debar...

CONCLUSION:

Tough deliberate, the plan of God for us is brilliant! His plan for us includes: **(PLACE ON SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- Rescuing us from the poverty stricken place...
- Being repositioned for a fruitful future rather than wallowing in the pain of past experiences...

- Restoration of the years that have been stolen...
- Becoming connected to people who can assist us in achieving our life purpose...
- Dining continually at the table of the King...
- Changing our residence from a place of defeat to a destiny of victory...

I want to conclude my thoughts here with a quote from Meister Eckhart - *“For however devoted you are to God, you may be sure that he is immeasurably more devoted to you.”* **(LEAVE ON SCREEN UNTIL END OF SERVICE)**